

The Second Coming of the Creative Director: Redefining the Role of the Artist in the Age of AI

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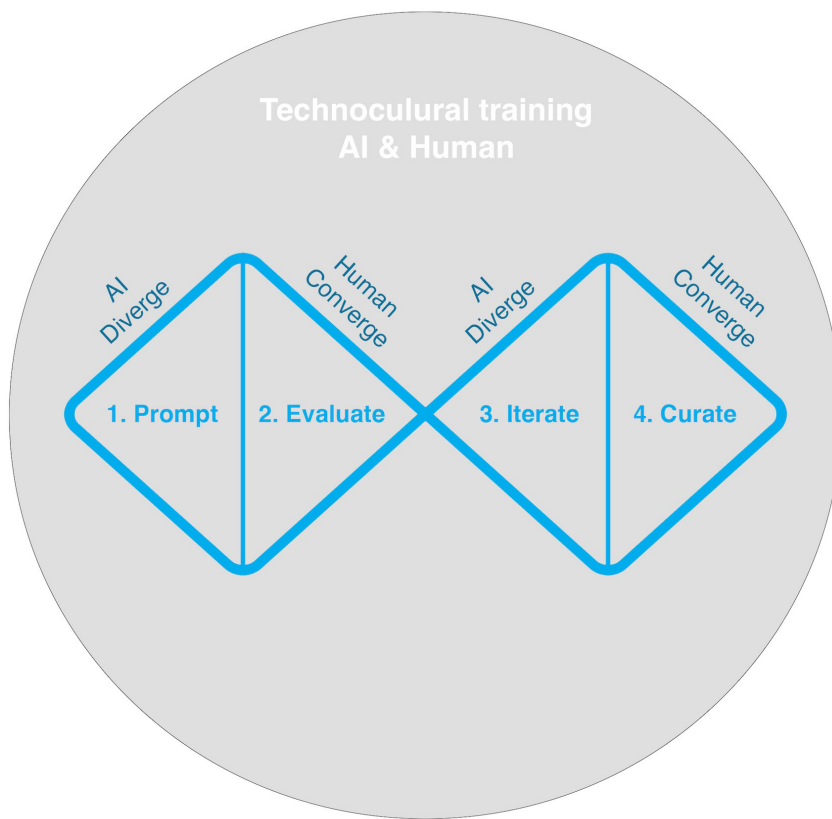
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ABSTRACT

The proliferation of AI tools across creative disciplines raises the question of what the future role of cultural practitioners might look like. As AI expands what can be produced and at what speed, it simultaneously alters how creative work is perceived by publics, institutions, and markets, with significant consequences already unfolding across the creative industries and the pedagogies that feed them. In response, this essay proposes that the emergent role for cultural practitioners resembles that of the creative director: a figure who does not primarily produce artworks, but directs human-machine co-creation by reducing abundance through judgement. The argument proceeds through a genealogy that situates the origins of creative direction in the 20th-century advertising boom, when mass media and organisational complexity turned creativity into an economic interface; and it goes on to connect this lineage to Data Capitalism's drive for AI-enabled productivity in the 21st century. Under these conditions, the key question shifts from access to technological tools to the capacities that sustain agency: preserving intention against metrics-based circulation and the shallowification of the Internet, while exposing an emergent AI aristocracy defined by evaluative competence, available time, and institutional support. To make human-AI co-creation legible as a rhythm, the paper introduces a revised version of the Double Diamond model that reframes creative thinking as a negotiation between intention and artefact within a dynamic technocultural milieu. The paper concludes by foregrounding education as decisive for training AI cultural practitioners able to assess, contextualise, and defend work under synthetic saturation. Consequently, the essay frames AI both through and beyond artistic disciplines, as a social and political apparatus whose effects on public life depend on whether criticality is cultivated or eroded across culture and education.



Introduction

The proliferation of generative systems does not simply introduce another toolkit into the studio; rather, it reconfigures the ontology of creative work by relocating where “making” takes place. As AI platforms co-produce images, sounds, and narratives, the artist-designer increasingly shifts from maker to meta-maker: a practitioner whose craft is expressed as the ability to orchestrate technological tools, delegate machine tasks, evaluate their outputs, and select them for circulation. This mode of creativity reconfigures the meaning of making and, thereby, the meaning of skill. Amid those changes, the core question shifts from whether such tools are accessible to the question of who retains agency within automated cultural production. In this context, an update to Hito Steyerl’s diagnosis of circulationism becomes possible: the “poor image” no longer primarily denotes low resolution, but low agency; in other words, images may look better than ever,

but they are more difficult to reclaim for critical purposes (Steyerl, 2009, 2013).

In this new cultural terrain, the “AI creative director” can be considered as a political figure as much as a professional one. The role highlights the problem of agency, as it identifies a human position that maintains control and accountability for what AI produces, while also being structurally pressured to accept speed, scale, and saturation as the default conditions of cultural work. A historical analogy that points to the importance of this shift can be found in the Renaissance workshop, where mastery was sustained through orchestration rather than singular execution. The Renaissance masters did not only paint or sculpt; they directed workshops, managed commissions, maintained signature styles, controlled reputations, and trained assistants within a proto-industrial cultural economy. However, the decisive difference from the present is that the Renaissance workshop did not define the wider economy. That broader economic function only started

The Double Diamond of the AI cultural practitioner.

materialising in the 20th century, when mass-media advertising made cultural innovation a generalised economic instrument. The creative director emerged at that critical junction. In the 21st century, AI reconfigures the same logic: with cultural innovation increasingly functioning as a generalised computational capacity, its economic and ideological effects also become generalised.

This essay develops a framework for understanding this renewed role by treating AI creativity not as a singular technological event, but as a complex technocultural regime within which humans and models continuously co-train one another. At the core of the essay's argument lies a revised Double Diamond model that re-frames creative thinking as a cyclical negotiation between intention and artefact, thereby making recognisable both the shifting configuration of agency in AI cultural production and the need to address it through education.

Aims and Objectives

The essay has four aims. First, to revisit the historical context of the 20th-century advertising boom as a means to explicate why creative direction becomes central to cultural work when media scale, organisational complexity, and market competition converge. Second, to situate the AI creative director within the economic paradigm of Data Capitalism, connecting cultural labour to extraction, platform governance, and metrics-based circulation. Third, to introduce a revised Double Diamond model as an epistemic device for understanding human-AI co-production as a rhythm (divergence and convergence) across prompting, evaluation, iteration, and curation. Fourth, to argue that the decisive scarce resource is not access to technological tools but criticality: the capacity to sustain agency against the shallowification of the Internet, which constitutes both a technical and a cultural condition.

Methods and Procedures

The paper adopts a mixed comparative and diagrammatic method, supported by a political-economic reading of contemporary technological platforms. First, it develops a historical comparison between

two conjunctures: the 20th-century creative director emerging from the institutionalisation of advertising and mass media (Marchand, 1985; Nixon, 2003); and the 21st-century AI creative director, emerging from platformed production and generative automation (van Dijck et al., 2018; Miller, 2019; Erickson, 2024; Bender, 2025; Chu et al., 2025). This comparison is complemented by a conceptual synthesis drawn from the political economy of platforms and data (Balaskas, 2015, 2017; Srnicek, 2016; Zuboff, 2019), media theory of attention and circulation (Citton, 2016; Steyerl, 2009, 2013), and technocultural accounts of AI as a social apparatus rather than a 'neutral' tool (Crawford, 2021; Pasquinelli, 2023).

Second, the diagrammatic approach is treated as a way of conceptualising and working with AI rather than as mere illustration. The proposed revised Double Diamond model articulates a framework of staging relations – human/machine, divergence/convergence, intention/artefact – without collapsing them into either technological determinism or credulous humanist reassurance. Thus, the model may operate as a basis for training, evaluation, and responsible institutional design in pedagogy.

Third, the paper reads AI creativity through the lens of Data Capitalism – the dominant economic paradigm of the past two decades, where cultural practice is formatted as algorithmically controlled, programmable, and corporate-owned data, and where value is extracted through attention, behavioural capture, and infrastructural control (Balaskas, 2015, 2017; Srnicek, 2016; Yeung, 2017; Zuboff, 2019). This framing is mobilised not to denounce technology, but to expose why agency is decisive in the context of AI: if creative work is absorbed into metrics-governed circulation, then the ability to preserve intention is a counter-capacity that must be taught.

Results

Creative Direction under Data Capitalism: From Mass-Media Interface to Algorithmic Stratification

The emergence of the creative director in the 20th century was a thoroughly economic invention – a managerial role aiming at translating industrial production into

cultural legibility at scale. In the interwar period, advertising played a decisive role in making modernity consumable, as it did not simply communicate the distinguishing features of products, but also organised people's aspirations and anxieties into visual narratives that could be shared (Marchand, 1985). That early phase already reveals the role's underlying logic: the transformation of cultural innovation into a reproducible economic instrument. Yet the full consolidation of creative direction came with the postwar economic boom, when advertising became the connective tissue of a rapidly expanding consumer economy. The shift from print to radio and then television multiplied audiences, compressed time and expanded competitive pressures, making message-medium coordination a continuous challenge. Inevitably, then, in a context of mass production, heightened competition between substitutable goods, and brand management, differentiation became a matter of urgency. The creative director naturally appeared in this new landscape as a stabilising figure: a managerial solution, as the "creative" had to be systematised to generate engaging variation while preserving brand coherence. In this light, the Creative Revolution of mid-century advertising can be read not only as an aesthetic shift, but also as an organisational innovation (Samuel, 2012).

This logic remains consistent as we move into the AI era. Today, the creative director returns as an interface under altered technical conditions, defined by the ability of generative systems to produce abundance. Yet abundance does not automatically generate value. The latter is the outcome of informed ideation, contextualisation, selection, and the capacity to defend decisions within algorithmic opacity. This entails that the "AI creative director" does not replace the artist-designer; it specifies the artist-designer's new function, within which authorship is performed through orchestration rather than direct making. The AI creative director is a practitioner who must hold together intention, realisation, and publicness as cultural work is increasingly automated and circulation increasingly based on real-time metrics and procedurality (Balaskas, 2026).

The difficulty of sustaining such orchestration becomes more evident when considered within the distinct conditions of

Data Capitalism. Over the past two decades, the main raw material and output of the economy have been programmable, corporate-owned information (Balaskas, 2017; Zuboff, 2019). This new paradigm can be seen as a particular stage in the evolution of Late Capitalism, catalysed by the launch of the World Wide Web in the 1990s (early phase) and the introduction of Web 2.0 in the mid-2000s (maturity). At the same time, Data Capitalism constitutes a powerful cultural milieu because of its three main characteristics: datatization, the algorithmic control of the economy, and the transition from consumption to production as the principal agent of economic expansion (user-generated content/data). In Data Capitalism, cultural production cannot escape being continuously captured as training materials, predictive assets, and behavioural signifiers. Speculation is thoroughly infrastructural in this context: it is not simply a financial *modus operandi*, but a cultural logic that reorganises value based on the anticipatory dimensions of perception and desire among online publics (Balaskas, 2015; Balaskas & Rito, 2021).

AI intensifies this condition by optimising aesthetic decisions for scale and speed. Accordingly, a stratification of agency emerges, given that AI tools can produce both shallow and deep results. The former are outputs that are immediately plausible yet conceptually thin, while the latter are the outcomes of slow evaluation, domain knowledge, and critical judgement. This is not a claim about the intrinsic 'quality' of AI outputs, but about the distribution of evaluative capacity around them. Such a stratification is rendered visible when examined through the lens of what we could call an "AI aristocracy": a class defined by access to the conditions that make the production and/or identification of deep results possible, rather than mere access to technology. These privileged conditions include education, time for assessment, technical training, institutional support, and the ability to scrutinise systems beyond their individual components. Recent labour-market and sector reports clearly identify this uneven distribution, showing stronger complementarities between AI and creativity in high-skill creative clusters, alongside acute concerns about the erosion of junior roles and training pathways (Erickson, 2024; Wang et al., 2025;

British Film Institute, 2025).

Therefore, the idea of an AI aristocracy should not be perceived simply as the establishment of an elite ‘taste,’ but as the diagnosis of uneven agency. The question “who can produce depth?” becomes inseparable from “who has been trained to recognise depth?” and, crucially, “who can afford the labour of evaluating depth?” Current evidence indicates that AI is reshaping information pathways in ways that compress the Web into fewer information layers, with AI summaries correlating with fewer clicks to external sources (Law & Guan, 2025; Chapekis & Lieb, 2025). Such reduction of labour is the direct result of search engines adapting to generative interfaces; however, it is also a key factor in raising the risk of the Internet becoming flatter and more self-referential, as infrastructural incentives favour speed and volume to an unprecedented extent. This combination of fewer layers (search shallowification) and ‘thinner’ layers (output shallowification) makes the retrieval of context more difficult for large strata of contemporary networked societies.

Towards a Technocultural Grammar of Agency: The Revised Double Diamond and Criticality as a Scarce Resource

This dual movement of externalisation and internalisation – training models and being trained by them – can be translated into a diagrammatic visual language bringing together both its procedural nature and its milieu. Adapting a revised version of the Double Diamond model of the UK Design Council offers a useful tool that illuminates the shift from ‘traditional’ creative thinking to AI creative thinking (Fig. 1). More specifically, with its alternating expansion and synthesis, the classic Double Diamond model (2004) makes design thinking legible as a rhythm: discover and define; develop and deliver; divergence and convergence (Design Council, n.d.). In the context of AI creativity, however, the Diamond is not simply the expression of a design process; rather, it constitutes an epistemic device for understanding and working with human-AI co-production as a cyclical negotiation between intention and artefact. Unlike recent co-creativity frameworks that map agency, control, or interaction as adjustable dimensions or design spaces, the Double Diamond is used here be-

cause it foregrounds temporality and the recursive rhythm of expansion, reduction, and editorial accountability (Moruzzi & Margarido, 2024; Davis et al., 2025).

In the revised Double Diamond model, the first expansion (“prompt”) marks AI divergence: the widening of possibility through a linguistic act that externalises intention into machinic space. Prompting is not just a ‘command’; it is a design hypothesis expressed in language, testing how a model internalises existing cultural referents and re-externalises them as an artefact. The first convergence (“evaluate”) marks human intervention: the moment when abundance must be reduced through judgement, not only in relation to surface quality but also in relation to original purpose, overall coherence, and the artefact’s ideological positioning – a first consideration of its potential role in the world. The second expansion (“iterate”) returns to AI divergence: a re-opening of the space of possibility through corrective feedback and the intentional production of difference. The final convergence (“curate”) returns to the human: the selection of outputs and their transformation into an accountable public proposition, where authorship is performed as editorial responsibility.

This rhythm resonates with Pasquinelli’s analysis of AI as a history of externalising mental designs into technical systems, and internalising materiality (including artefacts) back into the training of perception and cognition (Pasquinelli, 2023). As already suggested, this entails that AI and humans co-evolve through reciprocal modelling: on the one hand, technical infrastructures reshape what counts as intelligence, skill, and imagination; and, on the other hand, the dominant cultural input of humans defines the types of cultural outputs that should be ‘expected’ by the machine. In this sense, the revised Double Diamond does not describe a neutral workflow, but a two-way technocultural training whose dual aspect, nevertheless, does not mean that the two trajectories carry equal power or are likely to remain symmetrical.

Seen in these terms, the revised Double Diamond also elucidates why our focus must shift from attention to intention. If the late 20th and early 21st centuries consolidated an attention economy organised around the capture and monet-

isation of what users notice (Davenport & Beck, 2001; Citton, 2016), the present moment points towards an intention economy in which value increasingly depends on anticipating, steering, and operationalising what users seek to do (Searls, 2012; Zuboff, 2019) – a shift from monetising focus to monetising purpose. I use “intention” here more critically than in Searls’s original buyer-led formulation, as it becomes a site of extraction and optimisation within platformed environments (van Dijck et al., 2018; Zuboff, 2019). Under such conditions, agency is no longer measured by what one can buy or consume, or even produce, but by the capacity to preserve and revise intention within automated systems and their choice architectures (Yeung, 2017). The emerging discourse on an “agentic Web” makes this tension explicit: as AI agents begin to mediate browsing, summarisation, and action, the user risks becoming a variable inside a delegated chain of operations unless intention is actively sustained at each stage (Gent, 2025). This marks the clearest shift yet from access to agency: from the question “who can use the tools?” to the question “who can direct the tools, interrogate their outputs, and preserve a space for judgement that is not reducible to engagement metrics?” This is the point at which education becomes pivotal as the primary site where agency can be built. The ability to produce deep results and to refuse shallow ones as a cultural practitioner depends on the cultivation of critical skills. These include the understanding of art history as a repertoire of forms originating in specific political, economic, technological, and social environments; the study of cultural theory as an exercise in ideology, mediation, and institutional power; and the engagement with philosophy as a discipline of ethical problematisation. Such critical skills catalyse the realisation that images do not exist in a void – they emerge and are disseminated within histories of labour, extraction, representation, and exclusion. When curricula reduce theory in favour of faster production and more ‘market-aligned’ outputs, they reallocate agency away from students and toward platforms, because students are not trained to interpret, contest, and redesign. Notably, UNESCO’s guidance on generative AI in education and research

frames this as a matter of safeguarding human-centred judgement, transparency, and responsibility under conditions of automation (UNESCO, 2023).

As a result, the tutor’s role becomes strategic in a whole new light, shifting away from simply being a mentor for a particular craft. Tutors are mediators of critical traditions and conceptual challenges who train students to locate their practices within histories and conflicts. Such a mode of thinking stands in direct contradistinction to treating AI outputs as self-justifying, ‘natural’ and, in the end, ideologically ‘neutral’. This is precisely what the AI cultural practitioner must be able to do in professional contexts, too (Wang, Yang, & Luan, 2026). For instance, training a junior designer to become a senior designer is no longer primarily a story of technical progression. Instead, it is a question of whether the practitioner can reflectively direct workflows, evaluate outputs, defend decisions, and sustain accountability when quality is increasingly conflated with plausibility, and originality with mere recombination. Against this backdrop, criticality can be seen as a (counter-)infrastructural need: the scarce resource that prevents creativity from dissolving into an ocean of high-resolution, low-agency images.

Conclusions

Read retrospectively, the “Second Coming” in this essay’s title is not a messianic claim, but a way to highlight the return of a function within a different, much more volatile context. The genealogy of the creative director allows us to read the present as a time when the production of images has become a central component of the economic paradigm and is too complex to handle through singular formats. In the 20th century, the creative director stabilised creativity inside mass media and market competition, rendering novelty operational and legible. In the 21st century, the AI creative director is tasked with stabilising agency inside generative saturation, where cultural production is accelerated and captured by Data Capitalism’s predictive infrastructures. Therefore, the issue is not whether AI eliminates creative work as such, but how it redistributes authorship, evaluative labour, and entry routes

across uneven institutional settings. This shift from maker to meta-maker relocates craft into the governance of variation and the consolidation of meaning.

What becomes crucial, then, is the ability to preserve intention against metrics-based circulation and the shallowing of the Internet. The Double Diamond model of the AI cultural practitioner offers an epistemic device for making this clear as both rhythm and training: prompting, evaluation, iteration, and curation staged as an alternating AI divergence and human convergence. Most importantly, this function takes place within a shared technocultural milieu defining both human and technology – both how the machine changes the human, and how the human changes the machine. Accordingly, what ultimately differentiates shallow from deep AI results is the distribution of critical capacity around the

generative model. It is in this context that education is emphatically (re-)positioned as the primary site where agency can be protected, cultivated, and made transferable. This realisation may lead us to a further conclusion: the present wave of departmental closures across the arts and humanities and reductions of theory-driven assessments matters not only institutionally but culturally, because it risks weakening the very capacities through which cultural practitioners learn to evaluate, contextualise, and defend work under conditions of synthetic saturation. If the AI creative director is to become more than an operator of automated aesthetics, their role must be grounded in the humanities – in fields such as critical theory, art history, and philosophy. This is the only way in which AI-mediated creativity can remain intentional, accountable, and politically conscious.

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